

WHITE PAPER

The Canada–Kenya Textile Export Pipeline: What BC Residents Should Know

The secondhand clothing export model is not a charitable act. It is a waste transfer system — and BC participates in it.

Kasandy Foundation · KCEI Research Series · 2026

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This white paper presents publicly available data and analysis to support community education and policy discussion.

The Canada–Kenya Textile Export Pipeline

Every year, Canadians donate billions of garments to thrift stores, charity bins, and clothing drives with the belief that their cast-offs will clothe people in need. In reality, the majority of donated textiles that are not sold domestically are baled and exported to secondary markets in sub-Saharan Africa — primarily Ghana, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania, and Rwanda. This practice does not represent effective charity. It is a transnational waste transfer system that undermines local textile industries, creates environmental hazards in receiving countries, and allows wealthy nations to externalize the costs of overconsumption.

This paper documents the pipeline, its impact on Kenya specifically, and the case for BC communities to divert their unwanted textiles into local circular economy infrastructure such as the Kasandy Circular Economy Initiative (KCEI) instead.

Key findings

- An estimated 85% of donated Canadian textiles end up landfilled, incinerated, or exported rather than reused domestically
- Global annual trade in used clothing exceeds 4.5 million tonnes and is valued at USD \$4+ billion
- Ghana's Kantamanto Market — one of the world's largest used clothing markets — receives an estimated 15 million garments per week, of which 40% are rejected immediately as unsellable waste
- Rwanda banned used clothing imports in 2018; Kenya and Tanzania have explored similar restrictions due to industry decimation
- KCEI diverts post-consumer textiles into locally manufactured products, eliminating the export pipeline entirely for materials it processes

SECTION 1

How the Secondhand Clothing Export System Works

When a Canadian donates a jacket to a Salvation Army bin or drops clothing at an H&M; collection point, the visible narrative is straightforward: the garment will help someone in need. The operational reality is considerably more complex.

Major clothing collection organizations in Canada — including national charities and for-profit collectors — sort incoming donations into categories: premium items (suitable for resale in domestic stores), mid-grade items (for discount sale), and non-wearable items (torn, stained, or heavily worn). Typically, fewer than 20% of donations make it onto Canadian thrift store racks. The remainder is sorted and sold by weight to for-profit textile recyclers and exporters.

These exporters compress textiles into 45-kilogram bales and ship container loads to markets in sub-Saharan Africa. The destinations are diverse but the most significant import markets are Ghana, Kenya, Tanzania, Uganda, and Pakistan. In many of these markets, the imported clothes are sold in open-air trading centres by individual vendors who purchase bales wholesale and sell items retail, not knowing what condition the contents will be in until the bale is opened.

The economic logic for exporters

The export model is profitable because: (1) collection is performed at zero or negative cost to the exporter, who often receives charitable donations or government funding; (2) the cost of baling and shipping is low relative to the sale price of textiles in lower-income markets; and (3) no recycling infrastructure is required — the waste is simply moved. For charities and collection organizations, the revenue from bulk textile sales subsidizes domestic programs, creating a structural incentive to continue the export model regardless of impact.

SECTION 2

Impact on Kenya's Textile Economy

Kenya's domestic textile and apparel industry once employed hundreds of thousands of workers. In the 1980s and 1990s, as liberalization policies opened Kenyan markets to imported goods and mass used clothing arrived in growing volumes, the local industry collapsed. A 2017 analysis estimated that East Africa's collective textile sector had lost over 500,000 jobs since the 1970s, with used clothing imports widely cited as a contributing factor.

The used clothing trade in Kenya is now anchored in the mitumba market — a network of urban and peri-urban secondhand clothing vendors. Mitumba is not a casual market; it is a formal economic sector employing an estimated 300,000+ Kenyans. However, the economics of the mitumba trade are precarious. Vendors purchase bales without knowing their contents, and an increasing proportion of bales arriving from North America and Europe contain items that are too damaged or worn to sell.

“Between 30% and 50% of imported used clothing received in sub-Saharan African markets is immediately classified as waste upon arrival. This material is typically burned or landfilled in receiving countries with far less environmental regulation than the exporting nations.”

Kenya attempted to impose import restrictions on used clothing in 2016, citing industry impact. Pressure from the United States — which threatened trade sanctions under AGOA — forced the East African Community to back down. This episode illustrates the power asymmetry embedded in the export pipeline.

SECTION 3

The British Columbia Connection

British Columbia generates an estimated 65,000 tonnes of textile waste annually (University of Waterloo / Statistics Canada methodology applied to BC's share of Canadian population). The City of Vancouver's waste diversion programs do not currently have a dedicated textile collection and processing pathway: textiles placed in blue bins or black bins are sorted out as contamination. Most end up in landfill. A smaller quantity reaches donation bins, which, as described above, largely feed the export pipeline.

KCEI estimates that Vancouver alone generates approximately 20,000 tonnes of post-consumer textile waste annually. At current diversion rates (Statistics Canada, 2018: 58,895 tonnes diverted nationally from a 500,000-tonne waste stream — approximately 12%), roughly 2,400 tonnes of Vancouver's textile waste is diverted through donation or collection. Of this, the majority is exported or landfilled after sorting.

What KCEI does differently

- Collects post-consumer textiles directly from BC residents and businesses
- Processes them into manufactured products (acoustic bricks, playground surfaces, park furnishings) in Vancouver
- Zero export: every kilogram collected stays in BC
- Creates local inclusive employment rather than subsidizing overseas waste handling
- Provides traceability: from donor to finished product

SECTION 4

Policy Implications

The export pipeline model persists because recycling and remanufacturing infrastructure in Canada is underdeveloped relative to the volume of textiles generated. Addressing this requires:

- Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) for textiles: requiring brands and retailers to fund end-of-life management for the garments they sell
- Municipal textile collection systems with diversion targets: integrating textile collection into residential waste management

- Investment in local circular economy infrastructure: supporting facilities like KCEI that can absorb non-wearable textiles and transform them into products
- Consumer education: correcting the assumption that donation always equals positive impact

The Kasandy Foundation supports the development of all four policy pillars. KCEI itself represents the third: proof-of-concept, scalable local infrastructure.

Conclusion

The Canada–Kenya textile export pipeline is not a solution to textile waste — it is a deferral. It moves the problem from countries with strong environmental regulation and disposal infrastructure to countries with weaker systems and lower political power to resist. It undermines local industries, creates new waste streams, and provides Western donors with a misleading sense of charitable contribution.

BC residents who want their discarded textiles to generate genuine environmental and social benefit have an alternative: donate to KCEI. Every tonne of textiles processed by KCEI stays in BC, employs a local worker from an equity-deserving community, and becomes a product used in a local building, playground, or park.

Sources: University of Waterloo, Textile waste in Ontario, Canada: Opportunities for reuse and recycling (2023). OR Foundation, Dead White Man's Clothes (2021). WRAP, Textiles 2030. Statistics Canada, Waste Management Industry Survey (2018). World Bank, Tanzania Economic Update (2015). CBC News / Canadian Press coverage of EA Community textile trade dispute (2016–2017). kasandyfoundation.org.